

The 4-Line Proposal Template That Gets Replies

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Most freelancers write proposals that are too long, too generic, and too focused on themselves. Clients on Upwork receive 20-50 proposals per job. They spend about 10 seconds on each. This template is designed to survive those 10 seconds and get a reply. It has landed me 16 projects with a 100% Job Success Score.

THE 4-LINE FORMULA

Line 1: [SPECIFIC OBSERVATION about their business/problem – proves you read the post]

Line 2: [RELEVANT EXPERIENCE – one sentence, one result, with a number]

Line 3: [EXACTLY WHAT YOU WILL DO – specific deliverable, not vague promises]

Line 4: [LOW-FRICTION CTA – make it easy to say yes to a small next step]

LINE-BY-LINE BREAKDOWN: WHY EACH LINE WORKS

Line 1: The Specific Observation

What it does: Proves you actually read their job post. This is the line that separates you from the 40 copy-paste proposals they received.

How to write it: Reference something specific from their post, their website, or their business. Name the tool they mentioned. Quote a phrase they used. Point out a problem they described.

Template:

I noticed you're [SPECIFIC DETAIL FROM THEIR POST] – [YOUR OBSERVATION ABOUT WHY THAT'S A PROBLEM/OPPORTUNITY].

Examples:

- "I noticed you're manually screening candidates across 3 ATS systems — that's exactly the kind of bottleneck where 10+ hours/week disappear."
- "I saw you're using Go High Level but struggling with lead routing — the sub-account structure makes this tricky without custom API work."

- "Your post mentions you're spending \$5K/month on ads with inconsistent lead quality — I've solved this exact problem for a healthcare client."

Never open with: "Dear Hiring Manager," "I am a skilled freelancer," "I am excited to apply," "I have X years of experience." These are instant deletes.

Line 2: The Relevant Experience

What it does: Establishes credibility with ONE proof point. Not your life story. Not your resume. One relevant result.

How to write it: Pick the result from your experience that is closest to their problem. Include a number. Be specific about the industry if it matches.

Template:

I recently [BUILT/AUTOMATED/DESIGNED] [SPECIFIC SYSTEM] for a [SIMILAR CLIENT TYPE] — [ONE MEASURABLE RESULT].

Examples:

- "I recently built an automated screening pipeline for a staffing firm with 15 offices — it cut their hiring time from 6 weeks to under 1 week."
- "I built a 60-node n8n workflow for a construction company that manages 14,000 leads across 10 sub-accounts."
- "I set up an email automation system for a healthcare client that gets 93% open rates and reduced their ad spend by 70%."

Line 3: The Specific Deliverable

What it does: Tells them exactly what they will get. Not "I can help you." Not "I have ideas." A concrete deliverable.

How to write it: Describe the system, the tools, and the outcome in one sentence. Make it sound like something that already exists in your head.

Template:

For your project, I'd build [SPECIFIC SYSTEM] using [TOOLS] that [SPECIFIC OUTCOME THEY CARE ABOUT].

Examples:

- "For your project, I'd build an automated candidate intake and scoring system using Airtable + n8n that screens, ranks, and routes applicants to the right recruiter without any manual data entry."
- "I'd set up a CRM pipeline in Go High Level with automated follow-ups, lead scoring, and a dashboard so you can see exactly which leads are hot."
- "I'd build a content automation system that turns your weekly voice memo into 10 LinkedIn posts and 2 blog articles, matched to your brand voice."

Line 4: The Low-Friction CTA

What it does: Makes it easy to say yes. You are not asking them to hire you. You are asking for a conversation or offering free value.

How to write it: Offer something specific and small: a free Loom video, a quick call, or a free audit. Remove all risk from the next step.

Template:

Want me to [SMALL FREE ACTION]? Happy to [EASY NEXT STEP] – no obligation.

Examples:

- "Want me to record a quick 3-minute Loom walking through exactly how I'd set this up? No obligation — just wanted to show you the approach."
- "I can put together a free workflow diagram showing the automation structure. Want me to send it over?"
- "Happy to hop on a 15-minute call this week to map out the project — I'll come prepared with a rough scope."

Why 4 lines works: It takes 10-15 seconds to read. It proves you read the post (Line 1), shows you can deliver (Line 2), tells them what they get (Line 3), and makes it easy to reply (Line 4). Nothing else is needed.

5 COMPLETE EXAMPLE PROPOSALS

Example 1: AI Automation for Staffing Companies

Job post: "Need help automating our recruiting workflow. We screen candidates manually across spreadsheets and it's killing us."

I noticed you're manually screening candidates across spreadsheets – that's the exact bottleneck I automated for 15 staffing firms across LA, Texas, and Washington.

For one of those firms, I built an Airtable + n8n pipeline that cut their hiring time from 6 weeks to under 1 week and pushed their qualified candidate rate from 40% to 78%.

For your workflow, I'd build an automated intake system that parses resumes, scores candidates against your criteria using AI, and routes qualified applicants directly to the right recruiter – zero manual data entry.

Want me to send a quick 3-minute Loom showing exactly how this would work for your team? No obligation – just wanted to show you the approach.

Example 2: CRM Build-Out for Service Businesses

Job post: "We need a CRM set up in Go High Level. Currently tracking leads in spreadsheets and losing deals."

I saw you're tracking leads in spreadsheets and losing deals in the process – that's usually a sign your follow-up sequences have gaps, not that your leads are bad.

I built a 60-node n8n workflow for a metal and construction company that manages 14,000 leads across 10 Go High Level sub-accounts – including reverse-engineering their CRM's undocumented API.

For your business, I'd set up Go High Level with automated lead capture, a scoring pipeline, follow-up sequences, and a real-time dashboard so you can see every lead's status without opening a spreadsheet.

I can put together a free workflow diagram showing exactly how the automations would connect. Want me to send it over?

Example 3: Email Automation for Ecommerce

Job post: "Looking for someone to set up email automations. We have a Shopify store and barely send any emails."

Your Shopify store is sitting on a list of buyers who already trust you – the fact that you're barely emailing them means you're leaving the highest-ROI revenue channel untouched.

I recently set up email automations for a client where we hit 93% open rates (peaked at 98%) using segmented sequences and personalized triggers through Instantly.ai.

For your store, I'd build 5 core automated sequences: welcome series, abandoned cart recovery, post-purchase upsell, win-back for dormant customers, and a monthly product highlight – all triggered automatically based on customer behavior.

Happy to record a quick Loom walking through the exact sequence structure and expected revenue impact for your store. Want me to send it over?

Example 4: Content Automation for Coaches

Job post: "I'm a business coach. I know I need to post consistently but I never have time to create content."

The "I know I should post but never have time" problem is exactly what I solve – it's usually not a content problem, it's a systems problem. You have the expertise, you just need a pipeline that extracts it without eating your calendar.

I built a content automation system for an ecommerce founder that produces 42 posts per month from a single 20-minute voice memo – with 95% brand voice accuracy.

For you, I'd build a system where you record one 20-minute voice note per week, and it automatically generates 10 LinkedIn posts, 2 long-form articles, and a weekly email newsletter – all in your voice, all scheduled automatically.

Want me to do a free test run? Send me one voice memo and I'll turn it into 5 posts so you can see the quality before committing to anything.

Example 5: Lead Gen for Agencies

Job post: "Digital marketing agency looking for help generating leads. Currently relying on referrals and it's inconsistent."

Referrals are great until they dry up for a month and you're scrambling – the fix is a parallel outbound system that runs in the background so your pipeline is never empty.

I helped a healthcare client replace their paid ad dependency with website visitor tracking + Instantly.ai outbound – they now get the same clients at 30% of their original ad spend with a 32-40% conversion increase.

For your agency, I'd set up a lead gen system with three channels: LinkedIn prospecting automation, cold email sequences (personalized using AI), and website visitor identification with automatic outreach – all feeding into one dashboard so you see every lead in real time.

I can put together a free 15-minute strategy call where I map your current pipeline and show you where the gaps are. What does your Thursday look like?

COMMON MISTAKES THAT KILL PROPOSALS

Mistake	Why It Fails	What to Do Instead
Starting with "Dear Hiring Manager" or "I am a skilled..."	Generic. Reads like a template. Instant delete.	Start with a specific observation about THEIR business.
Writing more than 150 words	Clients skim. Long proposals signal "this person will over-complicate things."	4 lines. Say less. Link to a Loom for the rest.
Listing all your skills		

	Nobody cares about your skills. They care about their problem.	Mention ONE skill that solves THEIR specific problem.
Quoting a price in the proposal	You have zero context. Any number is either too high or leaves money on the table.	Get on a call first. Price based on value, not guessing.
No clear next step	If you don't tell them what to do next, they do nothing.	End with a specific, low-friction CTA.
Not including a Loom/Vidyard video	You are identical to every other text-only proposal.	ALWAYS include a short video. It is the #1 differentiator.
Copy-pasting the same proposal	Clients can tell. Upwork can detect it. Your response rate tanks.	Customize Line 1 and Line 3 for every single job post.

SUBJECT LINE FORMULAS

On some platforms (and for email pitches), you get a subject line. Make it count.

Formula	Example
[Result] for [Their Industry]	"6 weeks to 1 week hiring time — for staffing firms"
Quick question about [Their Specific Problem]	"Quick question about your candidate screening workflow"
I built this for a [Similar Company]	"I built this exact system for a 15-office staffing firm"
[Number] [Thing] in [Timeframe]	"14,000 leads automated in 10 sub-accounts"
Free [Deliverable] for [Company Name]	"Free workflow audit for Apex Staffing"

WHEN TO INCLUDE A VIDEO (ALWAYS) AND HOW

The rule: Always include a video. Always. A 2-3 minute Loom or Vidyard video attached to your proposal increases response rates by 3-5x. It proves you are a real person who actually looked at their project.

What to include in the video:

1. **First 15 seconds:** Say their name and company. Reference the specific project. ("Hi [Name], I saw your post about automating candidate screening for [Company] and I wanted to show you exactly how I'd approach this.")
2. **Next 60-90 seconds:** Share your screen. Show a similar project you've built, a workflow diagram, or a quick mockup. Walk them through it. ("Here's a system I built for a similar staffing company. You can see the automation starts when a resume hits the intake form...")
3. **Last 15 seconds:** CTA. ("If this looks like the right approach, let's hop on a quick 15-minute call to map it out for your specific workflow. Looking forward to hearing from you.")

Video tips:

- Keep it under 3 minutes. Nobody watches a 10-minute proposal video.
- Use Vidyard (free) or Loom (free). Both give you a trackable link so you know if they watched it.
- Clean your desktop before recording. Close Slack, email, and anything personal.
- Look at the camera when you talk. Share your screen only when showing work.
- Do not script it word-for-word. A slightly imperfect, genuine video beats a polished robotic one.

Time investment: A custom 3-minute video takes about 10 minutes total (prep + record + upload). If you send 5 proposals per day, that's 50 minutes on videos. That 50 minutes is the difference between a 5% response rate and a 20% response rate. Do the math.